

Discussion of
“Small Boats, Big Impacts”
by Bhatiya and Kadam

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Method

- Links daily Home Office counts of small-boat arrivals (2018–24) to > 240 k BES panel responses
- Exploits interview timing: 2-day migration shocks as quasi-random variation

→ a very cool high frequency geolocated dataset on boat arrivals.

Good News: Effect is economically Small & Short-lived

- 1000 extra arrivals in preceding 48h $\downarrow$ immigration support by 0.03σ
- Effect accounts for $\approx \frac{1}{3}$ of 2018–24 long-run sentiment decline
- Response highly transient (dissipates after ≈ 5 days)

Q – Descriptive trend support for more migrants (by category of migrants)?

S – The effect sizes are very small. c35K arrive yearly on boats.

Compare to election swings or inflation related swings

Q – Does it matter if the boat arrives in the local area of the respondent?

Bad News: Spillovers to Legal Migrants

- Negative shock reduces support for legal streams:
 - Foreign students (-0.26σ) > non-EU workers > family visas > EU workers

V – Most interesting finding given that loud anti-immigrants are usually pro-legal tracks of migration

V – Also implies an efficiency cost to businesses and universities.

Other thoughts

- **Sample limits:** focuses on UK-born White Britons; attitudes of minorities unknown: their views capture incentives. It is also true that recent top politicians from conservatives have been minorities - including migrants themselves.
- Policy shift link is weak: you can link this geolocated data to voting behavior of MPs and run the same exercise.
- Panel attrition issues - people who care about politics stay making the estimated effect larger?
- Would effects persist under sustained high inflows?